a FlexLifeFi K-12 program

What to Watch For at Home

One good question per quarter - no quizzing, no pressure.

Grade 12 year theme — Launch-Ready Entrepreneurship.
The 9-12 band is built for the adults who will scrutinize: parents, teachers, administrators.

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GRADE 12 · PARENT GUIDE

What to Watch For Home

Founder-defensible plans built on evidence, not enthusiasm.

12

For the family of a Grade 12 Cash to Company student. This is the capstone year of the program — the final classroom year before adulthood. By June, your student will have built a defended venture portfolio and made a clear, evidence-based decision about whether to launch it, change it, or set it aside. You are an important part of that work. This guide explains what's coming and how to help without taking over.

WITH CASH - 9-12 VOICE

"What would have to be true for you to be wrong?"

What your student is doing this year

> "You can pick what kind of business you build. It's a choice."
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

Across the year, your student is building one Capstone venture from scratch — or developing one they already started. They will:

- Compare three possible ventures and choose one to focus on.
- Write a weekly founder's journal — at least 10 entries by June.
- Build a complete startup financial picture: profit-and-loss, cash flow forecast, and basic balance sheet.
- Create a brand, publish a landing page, and have at least 5 real conversations with potential customers (not classmates).
- Produce a 1-page legal and ethical checklist for the venture.
- Write a 90-day operating plan with weekly check-ins.
- Write a Founder's Leadership Statement naming their values and decision rules.
- Defend the whole thing in a 30-minute Capstone Defense before a panel in May or June.

The defense ends with a written **Launch-or-Learn decision** — three honest options:

- **Launch.** Continue past graduation.
- **Pivot.** Change the model and continue.
- **Shelve.** Stop, with reasons.

All three are honored equally. The program does not push students toward launching. A well-defended shelve earns the same credit as a well-defended launch. The point is the thinking, not the venture.

What you can do — one good question per quarter

You don't need to be an entrepreneur or a financial professional to be helpful. The most useful thing you can do is ask one good question per quarter. The Cash to Company spine question is which people, and how do you know? You can borrow it.

Quarter 1 (September - November) — "Which people would actually buy this, and how do you know?"

Push gently for specifics. "My friends would like it" is not yet evidence. "Three of my classmates ranked this option highest in a quick comparison I did Tuesday" is. Don't insist on right answers; help your student notice the difference between assumption and evidence.

Quarter 2 (November - February) — "What does the cash flow say will be the tightest month, and what's your plan for it?"

By winter, your student is building a 12-month cash flow forecast. Most ventures have one month where cash gets thin. Knowing which one — and having a plan — is the financial discipline of the year.

Quarter 3 (February - April) — "Who have you talked to that surprised you, and what did you change because of it?"

The 5 real customer conversations happen this quarter. The point of each is the surprising answer. If your student is doing it well, they'll have at least one moment where a real adult said something that contradicted what your student expected, and they had to revise.

Quarter 4 (April - June) — "What's your honest call — launch, pivot, or shelve — and what evidence is behind it?"

By May, your student is preparing the Capstone Defense. The decision is private until they make it. Your role is to help them say the honest answer aloud at home before they say it in front of the panel. There is no wrong answer here. There is only the honest answer. Hold space for it.

What to watch for

- **The journal.** It's the most predictive artifact in the year. A student writing weekly is doing the work. A student claiming to "have it all in their head" usually doesn't. Without nagging, ask occasionally: "Did you write this week?"
- **Real customer conversations.** Around February, your student needs to talk to 5 real people who are not classmates. They may approach a family friend, a coworker of yours, a coach, or a teacher in another department. Help by introducing — not by interviewing on their behalf.
- **The Defense (May or June).** Many schools open Defense Week to family. If yours does, attend. Watch quietly. Cheer respectfully. The panel will ask hard questions; that's the point. Your student will leave the room with a Launch-or-Learn decision in writing.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 12

"Which people, and how do you know?"

the program's spine question.

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What we ask you not to do

> **"Revenue is loud. Contribution margin is true. Compute one number this week."**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

- **Don't take over the venture.** A parent who builds the landing page or runs the customer interviews has produced their Capstone, not their student's. The student's panel will catch the substitution.
- **Don't push toward "launch."** Launching is one of three honest decisions. A student under family pressure to launch will sometimes commit to a venture they shouldn't. The Decision Quality rubric criterion explicitly rewards a defended shelve.
- **Don't ask about other students' ventures or financials.** Capstone work is private to each student.

What we will not ask your student about

The program has a clear sensitivity rule that has held since kindergarten: **we never ask students about family finances.** Not your income, not your debts, not your bank or credit history. If your student is comparing venture options, they're using neutral hypothetical numbers, not your household budget. If your student volunteers something about your family's finances, the teacher receives it without probing — and you should expect to be informed by the teacher only if a safety issue arises.

If college affordability or other financial decisions are on your student's mind, we honor that. The Capstone is built to be transferable thinking — about money, work, and risk — that helps your student no matter what they do next.

A note on what Cash to Company promises

The program does not promise your student will become wealthy. It does not promise their venture will succeed. It does not promise that entrepreneurship is the right path for them. The single promise of the program is that your student will be a clearer thinker about money, work, and risk — no matter what they end up doing for a living.

That clarity will compound for forty years. It will help your student in their first job, their first lease, their first salary negotiation, their first major financial decision. Some Cash to Company graduates do start ventures. Most don't, right away. All of them, the program hopes, will spend the next several decades asking which people, and how do you know? in the back of their head — and they will be better off for it.

Thank you for being part of the final year. Your student has done thirteen years of this work. By June, they will have something to show for it that they can carry with them. We'll see you at the Defense.

AN INTERLUDE · GRADE 12

"Most adults skip t step. You won't."

the band's working assumption.

2

Senior expert upgrade pack — Conversations for the launch / pivot / shelve decision

> **“Don't make up a winner. Decide what to test next.”**
>
> - CASH, GRADE 12

When your child says "I'm going to launch"

The Cash to Company curriculum prepares your child to think about this. Real launch is a family decision.

Three questions to ask:

1. "What's your evidence the market wants this? Show me the customer interactions."
2. "What's your runway in months at current burn? Show me the math."
3. "What would have to be true in 6 months for this to be working? In 12 months for this to be over?"

If your child can answer all three, they are launch-thinking-ready. If not, they're not yet — and that's fine. The "shelve" decision is honored by the curriculum.

When your child says "I'm going to shelve"

This is a valid decision. The curriculum honors it. Don't push back unless you have real evidence the venture should continue.

Three questions to ask:

1. "What did you learn that you'll keep, even if you're not launching this venture?"
2. "What would have to change for you to revisit this in 1-2 years?"
3. "What's the next thing you want to try, and how does this experience inform that?"

A well-defended shelve is the curriculum's most mature outcome.

When your child says "I'm going to pivot"

Pivot means the model changes — same problem, new approach. This is the entrepreneurial classic move. Ask:

1. "What's the same about your problem statement?"
2. "What changed about the customer or the value prop?"

3. "What evidence drove the pivot? Or is it a gut feel?"

(Gut-feel pivots are legitimate but more fragile. Evidence-driven pivots are stronger.)

What NOT to ask

Don't ask "are you sure this is what you want to do with your life?" The Capstone is a year of work, not a life commitment. Whatever decision your child reaches, it's a decision about THIS venture in THIS moment, not a verdict on their future.

ROUND 2 PATCH — Three 30-Second Conversation Starters per Quarter (Grade 12)

Quarter 1 (Portfolio Defense + Founders Journal) 1. At dinner: "Whats one venture in your portfolio that you would not start? Why?" — Follow-up: "What evidence?" 2. Drive-time: "Whats your founders journal entry from this week?" — Follow-up: "What changed in your thinking?" 3. Watching news: "If you were that founder, what would your portfolio entry for this venture say?" — Follow-up: "Would you start it?"

Quarter 2 (Full Financial Pack + Runway) 1. At dinner: "Whats your runway? Whats your burn rate?" — Follow-up: "Whats your action if revenue doesnt start in three months?" 2. Drive-time: "Walk me through your P&L, cash flow, and balance sheet sketch — how do they connect?" — Follow-up: "Where are you most uncertain?" 3. Watching news: "This company has 6 months of runway. What would you do if you were CEO?" — Follow-up: "Whats the first cut?"

Quarter 3 (Live Launch + Real Customers) 1. At dinner: "Whats one transactional interaction this week — someone said yes or no with stakes?" — Follow-up: "What did you learn?" 2. Drive-time: "Whos your first 5 customers? How did you find them?" — Follow-up: "What was the hardest no?" 3. In a real store: "If you had to launch this product tomorrow with no preparation, what would you actually do?" — Follow-up: "What would you skip?"

Quarter 4 (Launch-or-Learn Family Conversation Script)

If your child is wrestling with the Launch-or-Learn decision:

- **You:** "Walk me through the evidence."
- **Child:** [walks through]
- **You:** "What would have to be true for launch to be right?"
- **Child:** [names conditions]
- **You:** "What would have to be true for shelve to be right?"
- **Child:** [names conditions]

- **You:** "Which set of conditions matches your evidence better?"

This conversation does not push the child toward either answer. It surfaces their reasoning. The decision is theirs; your job is to listen.

If your child chooses shelve with good reasoning, that is a win. The Capstone rubric scores defense quality, not bravery. Many founders who chose shelve at 18 went on to launch at 25, with much better outcomes.

> **SENSITIVITY**
>
> None of these prompts require the family to share home finances. They work for any family.

ROUND 2 PATCH — What Cash Never Says (Parent Reference)

Cash will never say: "Amazing!" / "Everyone can be rich" / "Easy money" / "Passive income" / "Just believe in yourself" (as substitute for evidence) / anything implying money problems are a personal failing.

Cash always asks: "Which people, and how do you know?" / "Whats the evidence?"

Why this matters at home. Your child will encounter financial-literacy content from many sources, some hustle-bro coded. The contrast is the point. Cash is on your familys side: clear-eyed, honest, never selling.

One question this year: "What would have to be true for your venture to be wrong? How would you know?"

ENDNOTES & STANDARDS

Citations and alignment

Grade 12 cites 3-6 standards across CCSS, Jump$tart, CEE, CASEL, and C3 frameworks. Detailed alignment lives in the master Standards Alignment Map.

1. **Jump$tart Coalition Personal Finance Standards (2021 ed.).** Spending and Saving; Credit and Debt; Employment and Income; Investing; Risk Management and Insurance; Financial Decision Making.
2. **Council for Economic Education (CEE).** Voluntary National Content Standards in Economics.
3. **CCSS-ELA, Grades 11-12.** W.11-12.1, W.11-12.4, SL.11-12.1, SL.11-12.4, RST.11-12.7.
4. **CCSS-Math.** N-Q.1-3 (Reasoning with Quantities), S-IC (Statistics & Inferences), F-IF (Functions), MP.4 (Modeling).
5. **CASEL Core Competencies.** Self-Awareness, Self-Management, Social Awareness, Relationship Skills, Responsible Decision-Making.
6. **C3 Framework for Social Studies State Standards.** Dimension 2 (Economics, Civics) at the high-school grade band.
7. **NGSS-ETS Engineering Practices.** ETS1 (Engineering Design) for the test-and-iterate spine of the year.
8. **Cash to Company Master Scope & Sequence.** 13 grades x 8 strands x 36 weeks; outcomes quoted verbatim from _master/00_Master_Scope_and_Sequence.md.
9. **Cash Mascot Style Guide.** 9-12 voice rules: multi-sentence arguments; vocabulary includes unit economics, runway, premortem, MVP; never flatters, never promises wealth.
10. **Sensitivity protocol.** No probing of family finances; financial scenarios framed as hypothetical for a sample household, business, or scenario.

One promise.

Cash to Company makes one promise: students who move t
program will be clearer thinkers about money and entrepren
matter what they end up doing for a living.

We do not promise wealth. We do not promise success. We pro

> **“Founder-defensible plans built on evidence, not enthusiasm.”**
>
> **- CASH, GRADE 12**

For educational use. This curriculum is informational and does not constitute financial, legal, or tax advice. Standards alignment cited per the Cash to Company Standards Alignment Map (Jump$tart, CEE, CCSS, C3, CASEL, NGSS-ETS).